沙漠里的驼铃

算不出来的东西

Camel Bells in the Desert

The Things You Cannot Count

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic)

Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 5 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 叮当[1]，叮当……很多年以后，康宁[2]还常常想起沙漠里的驼铃[3]声。那是唐朝[4]开元[5]年间，他十七岁，第一次跟着商队，从长安[6]出发，走向很远的西方。出发以前，他以为这条路上只有两样东西：货和钱。回来的时候，他才明白，自己想错了。

长安的西市[7]

2 康宁的家在长安西市的旁边。他们家是粟特[8]人，老家在很远的康国[9]，也就是撒马尔罕[10]，所以姓康[11]。从爷爷那时候开始，康家就在长安做买卖，卖丝绸[12]、纸和从西方运来的香料[13]。康宁在长安出生，在长安长大，汉语说得比粟特语[14]还好。

3 西市是长安最热闹的地方。

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1 叮当 *dīngdāng* ding-dong
2 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
3 驼铃 *tuólíng* camel bell
4 唐朝 *Tángcháo* Tang dynasty (618–907)
5 开元 *Kāiyuán* Kaiyuan reign era (713–741)
6 长安 *Cháng'ān* Chang'an, the Tang capital
7 西市 *Xīshì* the West Market of Chang'an
8 粟特 *Sùtè* Sogdian
9 康国 *Kāngguó* Kang State (Samarkand)
10 撒马尔罕 *Sāmǎ'ěrhǎn* Samarkand
11 康 *Kāng* Kang (surname)
12 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
13 香料 *xiāngliào* spices
14 粟特语 *Sùtèyǔ* Sogdian language

Ding-dong, ding-dong... Many years later, Kang Ning still often thought of the sound of camel bells in the desert. It was the Kaiyuan era of the Tang dynasty. He was seventeen, and for the first time he set out from Chang'an with a caravan, heading for the far-off West. Before he left, he thought there were only two things on this road: goods and money. By the time he came back, he understood that he had been wrong. 1

The West Market of Chang'an

Kang Ning's home was beside the West Market of Chang'an. His family were Sogdians whose old home was the distant Kang State, that is, Samarkand, and so their surname was Kang. Since his grandfather's time, the Kang family had traded in Chang'an, selling silk, paper, and spices brought from the West. Kang Ning was born and raised in Chang'an, and he spoke Chinese even better than Sogdian. 2

The West Market was the liveliest place in Chang'an. 3

依照官府的规定，每天中午敲鼓，市场才开门；太阳落山以前，人们就得离开。市场里有卖马的，卖酒的，卖玻璃杯的，到处都是穿着不同衣服、说着不同语言的人。小时候，康宁[1]最喜欢站在市场门口，看从西方回来的商队：骆驼[2]一头接一头，身上的铃叮当[3]作响，好像是从另[4]一个世界走来的。

不过，康宁关心的不是远处的故事，而是数字。他从小跟着父亲学做买卖，一匹丝绸[5]在长安[6]值多少钱，到了西方能卖多少钱，他都记得清清楚楚。“爸爸，”他常说，“做买卖很简单，就是在便宜的地方买，到贵的地方卖。”父亲康福[7]听了，只是笑了笑，不说话。

这一年春天，商队的首领老石[8]来到康[9]家。老石五十多岁，脸被太阳晒得黑黑的，已经走过这条路二十多次了。

1 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
2 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
3 叮当 *dīngdāng* ding-dong
4 另 *lìng* another
5 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
6 长安 *Cháng'ān* Chang'an, the Tang capital
7 康福 *Kāng Fú* Kang Fu
8 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
9 康 *Kāng* Kang (surname)

By official rule, the market opened only when the drum was beaten at noon, and people had to leave before sunset. There were people selling horses, wine and glass cups, and everywhere were people in different clothes speaking different languages. As a child, Kang Ning loved standing at the market gate watching caravans come back from the West: camel after camel, the bells on them jingling, as if they had walked out of another world. 3

Yet what Kang Ning cared about was not stories of faraway places, but numbers. He had learned trading from his father since childhood; how much a bolt of silk was worth in Chang'an and how much it would fetch in the West, he remembered exactly. "Dad," he often said, "trading is simple: you buy where things are cheap and sell where they're dear." His father, Kang Fu, would just smile and say nothing. 4

That spring, Old Shi, the leader of a caravan, came to the Kang house. Old Shi was over fifty, his face burned dark by the sun, and he had already travelled this road more than twenty times. 5

父亲对康宁[1]说："你总说做买卖很简单。今年，你跟老石[2]去一次撒马尔罕[3]吧。"他决定将家里最好的三十匹丝绸[4]和一些纸交给康宁，让他自己去卖。康宁高兴得跳了起来。母亲担心路上太苦，怕他受不了；他却不顾母亲的担心，那天就开始收拾行李。

出发

出发以前，父亲带康宁去官府办"过所[5]"。过所是一种出门旅行用的证明，上面写着商人的名字、年龄，带了多少人、多少头骆驼[6]和多少货。依照唐朝[7]的法律，商人每过一个关口，都要拿出过所让士兵检查，没有过所的人不能出关。康宁觉得很麻烦："这么多规定，有什么用？"父亲说："路越长，越需要规定。"

1 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
2 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
3 撒马尔罕 *Sāmǎ'ěrhǎn* Samarkand
4 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
5 过所 *guòsuǒ* travel permit (Tang)
6 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
7 唐朝 *Tángcháo* Tang dynasty (618–907)

His father said to Kang Ning, "You always say trading is simple. This year, go 5
to Samarkand with Old Shi." He decided to hand the family's thirty best bolts of silk and some paper over to Kang Ning, and let him sell them himself. Kang Ning jumped for joy. His mother worried the road would be too hard and that he wouldn't be able to bear it, but he paid no heed to her worries and started packing that very day.

Setting Out

Before they left, his father took Kang Ning to the government office to get a 6
guosuo. A guosuo was a pass for travelling, listing the merchant's name and age, and how many people, camels and goods he had with him. Under Tang law, at every checkpoint a merchant had to show his guosuo to the soldiers, and nobody without one could leave through the pass. Kang Ning found it a nuisance. "So many rules, what's the use?" His father said, "The longer the road, the more it needs rules."

7 商队一共有二十多个人，四十多头骆驼[1]。骆驼背上是一匹一匹的丝绸[2]，还有一包一包的纸。每头骆驼身上都挂着一个铃。老石[3]说：“在沙漠里，铃声就是大家的耳朵。听见铃声，就知道骆驼在哪儿，人在哪儿。”

8 他们从长安[4]的开远门[5]出发。据说城门外有一块石头，上面写着“西去安西[6]九千九百里”。商队一路向西，经过凉州[7]、甘州[8]、肃州[9]。白天走路，晚上休息。走了一个多月，康宁[10]的脚走破了，脸也晒破了皮。以往在长安，他觉得跟着商队走很浪漫；现在他才知道，这样的日子不是谁都过得了的。

9 老石话不多，可是什么都看在眼里。一天晚上，康宁坐在火堆旁边算钱，老石问他在算什么。

1 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
2 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
3 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
4 长安 *Cháng'ān* Chang'an, the Tang capital
5 开远门 *Kāiyuǎnmén* Kaiyuan Gate, northwest gate of Chang'an
6 安西 *Ānxī* Anxi, Tang protectorate in the west
7 凉州 *Liángzhōu* Liangzhou (today's Wuwei)
8 甘州 *Gānzhōu* Ganzhou (today's Zhangye)
9 肃州 *Sùzhōu* Suzhou (today's Jiuquan)
10 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning

The caravan had more than twenty people and over forty camels. On the camels' backs were bolt upon bolt of silk, and bundle upon bundle of paper. Every camel had a bell hanging on it. Old Shi said, "In the desert, the bells are everyone's ears. Hear the bells, and you know where the camels are and where the people are." 7

They set out from the Kaiyuan Gate of Chang'an. It is said that outside the gate stood a stone inscribed "Nine thousand nine hundred li west to Anxi". The caravan went west all the way, through Liangzhou, Ganzhou and Suzhou. They walked by day and rested at night. After more than a month, Kang Ning's feet were worn raw and the skin on his face was sunburned and peeling. Back in Chang'an he had thought travelling with a caravan was romantic; only now did he know that not just anyone could stand this kind of life. 8

Old Shi didn't say much, but he noticed everything. One evening Kang Ning sat by the campfire doing sums, and Old Shi asked him what he was working out. 9

9 “我在算这一路花了多少钱。”康宁[1]说，“给骆驼[2]买草，过关口，找地方住……要是能少花一点，我们就能多挣一点。”老石[3]看了看他的本子，笑着说：“你算得很清楚。可是这条路上，有些东西是算不出来的。”

敦煌[4]

10 又走了二十多天，他们到了敦煌。敦煌当时也叫沙州[5]，是走进大沙漠以前最后一座大城。城里住着汉人[6]、粟特[7]人和别的民族的人。城外的山上有很多石窟[8]，就是后来有名的莫高窟[9]。石窟的墙上画着佛[10]和弹琵琶[11]的飞天[12]，康宁站在那儿看了很久。他发现，画里还有拉着骆驼的胡人[13]商人，长得跟他父亲有点像。

1 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
2 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
3 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
4 敦煌 *Dūnhuáng* Dunhuang
5 沙州 *Shāzhōu* Shazhou, Tang name for Dunhuang
6 汉人 *Hànrén* Han Chinese
7 粟特 *Sùtè* Sogdian
8 石窟 *shíkū* cave temple
9 莫高窟 *Mògāokū* Mogao Caves
10 佛 *Fó* the Buddha
11 琵琶 *pípá* pipa, Chinese lute
12 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (Buddhist art)
13 胡人 *húrén* foreigner from the west

"I'm working out how much we've spent on the way," Kang Ning said. "Fod- 9
der for the camels, getting through checkpoints, finding places to stay... If we could spend a bit less, we could earn a bit more." Old Shi looked at his notebook and smiled. "Your sums are very clear. But on this road, some things can't be worked out with numbers."

Dunhuang

After another twenty-odd days they reached Dunhuang. At that time Dun- 10
huang was also called Shazhou; it was the last big city before the great desert. Han Chinese, Sogdians and people of other peoples lived in the city. In the hills outside the city were many cave temples, the ones that later became famous as the Mogao Caves. The cave walls were painted with Buddhas and flying apsaras playing the pipa, and Kang Ning stood there looking for a long time. He noticed that the paintings also showed foreign merchants leading camels, who looked a little like his father.

11 商队要在敦煌[†]休息几天，也要在这里卖掉一部分丝绸[‡]。城里有一位姓张的掌柜，跟老石[§]做了十几年生意。以往每一年，他们都会先说好第二年的价格，第二年老石就按这个价格卖给他二十匹丝绸。今年，张掌柜早就在等他们了。

12 可是第二天，另外一个商人找到了康宁[¶]。那个人说，今年从长安[*]来的丝绸很少，敦煌的丝绸价格涨了一半。“你们的丝绸，我出比张掌柜高一半的价钱，全买了！”康宁的心跳得很快。他马上算了一下：要是卖给这个人，能多挣不少钱。他跑去找老石：“石叔[#]，我们把丝绸卖给他吧！张掌柜的价格太低了，卖给张掌柜，我们会有很大的损失。”

† 敦煌 *Dūnhuáng* Dunhuang
‡ 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
§ 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
¶ 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
* 长安 *Cháng'ān* Chang'an, the Tang capital
石叔 *Shí Shū* Uncle Shi

The caravan would rest in Dunhuang for a few days, and would also sell 11
part of its silk there. In the city lived a shopkeeper named Zhang who had done business with Old Shi for more than ten years. In past years they had always agreed on the next year's price in advance, and the following year Old Shi would sell him twenty bolts of silk at that price. This year, Shopkeeper Zhang had been waiting for them for a long time.

But the next day another merchant sought out Kang Ning. The man said 12
that little silk had come from Chang'an this year, and silk prices in Dunhuang had gone up by half. "I'll pay half as much again as Shopkeeper Zhang, and take all your silk!" Kang Ning's heart raced. He worked it out at once: selling to this man would earn them a good deal more. He ran to find Old Shi. "Uncle Shi, let's sell the silk to him! Shopkeeper Zhang's price is too low. If we sell to Zhang, we'll lose a lot."

13 老石[†]摇了摇头：“不行。去年我们跟张掌柜说好了，今年按这个价格卖给他。依照我们商队的规矩[‡]，说好的事，就不能改。”“可是那只是一句话呀，又没有写下来！”康宁[§]着急地说。

“正因为只是一句话，”老石说，“才更要守。这点损失，我们承担得起；丢了信用[¶]，我们可承担不起。一个商人要是不顾诚信，只看眼前的钱，在这条路上是走不远的。”

14 最后，丝绸[*]还是按原来的价格卖给了张掌柜。康宁心里很不高兴，一个晚上都没跟老石说话。商队出发那天早上，张掌柜却来送他们了。他拉着老石的手说：“今年丝绸这么贵，你们本来可以卖给别人。这件事，我记住了。”他送给商队十几袋水和干粮，还告诉老石：前面那片沙漠里，有一口老井[#]的水已经干了，最好走北边那条路。

† 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
‡ 规矩 *guīju* rules, custom
§ 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
¶ 信用 *xìnyòng* trustworthiness, good name
* 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
井 *jǐng* well

Old Shi shook his head. "No. Last year we agreed with Shopkeeper Zhang 13
to sell to him at this price this year. By the rules of our caravan, once something is agreed, it can't be changed." "But that was only words. It wasn't even written down!" Kang Ning said anxiously. "Precisely because it was only words," said Old Shi, "we must keep them all the more. A small loss like this we can afford; losing our good name is something we can't afford. A merchant who ignores good faith and only looks at the money in front of him won't get far on this road."

In the end the silk was still sold to Shopkeeper Zhang at the original price. 14
Kang Ning was very unhappy and didn't say a word to Old Shi all evening. But on the morning the caravan set off, Shopkeeper Zhang came to see them off. He took Old Shi's hand and said, "With silk so dear this year, you could have sold it to someone else. I won't forget this." He gave the caravan a dozen or so bags of water and dry rations, and told Old Shi that an old well in the desert ahead had run dry, so they had better take the northern route.

沙尘暴[1]

15 离开敦煌[2]以后，商队走进了大沙漠。四周什么也没有，只有黄色的沙子和蓝色的天。白天太阳像火一样，晚上又冷得让人睡不着。康宁[3]这才知道，在沙漠里，最宝贵的东西不是丝绸[4]，而是水。凭张掌柜的消息，老石[5]带大家走了北边的路，果然在第五天找到了一口有水的井[6]。康宁看着井里的水，心里想：要是那天我们把丝绸卖给了别人，张掌柜还会告诉我们这个消息吗？

16 第八天下午，天边忽然出现了一道黄色的“墙”，而且越来越近。老石大声喊：“沙尘暴来了！让骆驼[7]跪[8]下！大家躲在骆驼后面！”话还没说完，大风就到了。天一下子黑了，沙子打在脸上，像针一样疼。康宁什么都看不见，只能用衣服把头包住，紧紧地靠着自己的骆驼。

1 沙尘暴 *shāchénbào* sandstorm
2 敦煌 *Dūnhuáng* Dunhuang
3 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
4 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
5 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
6 井 *jǐng* well
7 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
8 跪 *guì* to kneel

The Sandstorm

After leaving Dunhuang, the caravan entered the great desert. All around 15
there was nothing but yellow sand and blue sky. By day the sun was like fire; at night it was so cold you couldn't sleep. Only now did Kang Ning realize that in the desert the most precious thing was not silk but water. Going by Shopkeeper Zhang's information, Old Shi led everyone along the northern route, and sure enough, on the fifth day they found a well with water in it. Looking at the water in the well, Kang Ning thought: if we had sold the silk to someone else that day, would Shopkeeper Zhang still have told us this?

On the afternoon of the eighth day, a yellow "wall" suddenly appeared on 16
the horizon, and it was getting closer and closer. Old Shi shouted, "Sandstorm! Make the camels kneel! Everyone get behind the camels!" Before he had finished speaking, the wind was upon them. The sky went dark all at once, and the sand struck their faces, stinging like needles. Kang Ning couldn't see a thing; all he could do was wrap his head in his clothes and press tight against his camel.

17 在风声中，他忽然听见有一个铃声越来越远——有一头骆驼[1]被吓坏了，跑了！那是一头老骆驼，大家叫它“老灰[2]”，背上是康[3]家最好的十匹丝绸[4]。康宁[5]什么也没想，不顾老石[6]在后面大声叫他，跟着铃声冲进了风里。

18 他不知道自己跑了多远。风太大了，他摔倒了好几次，又爬起来。他看不见路，只能凭耳朵去找那个铃声。叮当[7]，叮当……终于，他在一个沙堆下面找到了老灰。它倒在地上，一条前腿受了伤，站不起来了。康宁抱着它的头，一个人和一头骆驼，在风里等了很久很久。

19 风停的时候，已经是晚上了。远处传来了铃声和喊声，是老石带着两个人找来了。老石看见他，先生气地骂了一句：“你不要命[8]了！”然后又把自己的水袋递给了他。

1 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
2 老灰 *Lǎo Huī* Old Grey (a camel)
3 康 *Kāng* Kang (surname)
4 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
5 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
6 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
7 叮当 *dīngdāng* ding-dong
8 命 *mìng* life

Through the howl of the wind, he suddenly heard one bell growing fainter 17
and fainter: a camel had panicked and run off! It was an old camel everyone called "Old Grey", and on its back were ten of the Kang family's best bolts of silk. Without a second thought, and ignoring Old Shi shouting after him, Kang Ning followed the bell and rushed into the wind.

He didn't know how far he ran. The wind was so strong that he fell down 18
several times and got up again. He couldn't see the way, and could only follow the bell by ear. Ding-dong, ding-dong... At last he found Old Grey at the foot of a dune. It had collapsed on the ground; one of its front legs was hurt and it couldn't get up. Kang Ning held its head, and the two of them, a boy and a camel, waited in the wind for a long, long time.

By the time the wind dropped, it was already night. From far away came the 19
sound of bells and shouting: Old Shi had come looking for him with two men. When Old Shi saw him, he first cursed angrily, "Do you want to get yourself killed?", and then handed him his own water bag.

一头受伤的骆驼[1]

20 第二天，大家检查了老灰[2]的腿。腿没有断，可是伤得很重，它走得很慢，也不能再背东西了。老石[3]看了很久，最后说："依照路上的规矩[4]，走不了的骆驼只能留下。我们的水和粮食都不多，不能为了一头骆驼，让大家都在沙漠里等。"

21 这句话要是在以往，康宁[5]一定会同意。一头老骆驼值多少钱，他心里很清楚：它没有十匹丝绸[6]值钱，更没有大家的安全重要。可是现在，他想起昨天在风里，老灰把头靠在他身上的样子。他说："石叔[7]，它的货我来背。我走在最后面，不会让大家等的。"

22 大家都劝他：在沙漠里走路已经很累了，再背东西，会把身体累坏的。

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1 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
2 老灰 *Lǎo Huī* Old Grey (a camel)
3 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
4 规矩 *guīju* rules, custom
5 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
6 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
7 石叔 *Shí Shū* Uncle Shi

An Injured Camel

The next day, everyone examined Old Grey's leg. The leg wasn't broken, 20
but it was badly hurt; the camel walked very slowly and could no longer carry a load. Old Shi looked for a long time and finally said, "By the custom of the road, a camel that can't walk has to be left behind. We don't have much water or food, and we can't make everyone wait in the desert for one camel."

In the past, Kang Ning would certainly have agreed with this. He knew 21
perfectly well what an old camel was worth: less than ten bolts of silk, and far less important than everyone's safety. But now he remembered how, in the wind the day before, Old Grey had leaned its head against him. He said, "Uncle Shi, I'll carry its load. I'll walk at the very back, and I won't make anyone wait."

Everyone tried to talk him out of it: walking in the desert was exhausting 22
enough, and carrying a load as well would wear him out.

22 康宁[†]不顾大家的反对，把老灰[‡]的丝绸[§]分成几份，一部分放到别的骆驼[¶]背上，一部分自己背。以后的每一天，他都拉着老灰走在商队的最后面，老灰的铃声一直在他耳边响着。

23 那几天是康宁这辈子最累的日子。他的肩被压红了，脚也走破了，可是他一次也没有让商队等他。晚上休息的时候，他把自己的水分一点给老灰喝。老石[*]什么也没说，只是有一天晚上，悄悄地把一块干净的布包在了老灰受伤的腿上。

24 半个月以后，他们终于走出了沙漠，到了西州[#]。在那里，老灰的腿慢慢好了起来。老石对康宁说："以往我带过很多年轻人，他们都会算钱，可是很少有人愿意为一头老骆驼这么辛苦。在这条路上，骆驼信你，伙伴信你，做买卖的人也信你，你才能走得远。"

† 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
‡ 老灰 *Lǎo Huī* Old Grey (a camel)
§ 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
¶ 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
* 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
\# 西州 *Xīzhōu* Xizhou (today's Turpan)

Ignoring their objections, Kang Ning divided Old Grey's silk into several bun- 22
dles, putting some on the other camels and carrying some himself. Every day after that he led Old Grey at the very back of the caravan, and Old Grey's bell rang in his ears the whole time.

Those were the most exhausting days of Kang Ning's life. His shoulders 23
were rubbed red by the load and his feet were worn raw, but not once did he make the caravan wait for him. In the evenings when they rested, he shared a little of his own water with Old Grey. Old Shi said nothing, except that one night he quietly wrapped a clean cloth around Old Grey's injured leg.

Half a month later they finally came out of the desert and reached Xizhou. 24
There, Old Grey's leg slowly began to heal. Old Shi said to Kang Ning, "Over the years I've taken many young men along. They could all count money, but very few were willing to go through so much for an old camel. On this road, only when your camels trust you, your companions trust you and the people you trade with trust you, can you go far."

24 康宁[1]这才明白，那天晚上在火堆旁边，老石[2]说的“算不出来的东西”是什么。

带回来的东西

25 后来，商队经过龟兹[3]，翻过高高的葱岭[4]，在离开长安[5]大约半年以后，终于到了撒马尔罕[6]。这是康[7]家的老家。城外到处是葡萄园，人们说着他从小在家里听的粟特语[8]。康宁依照父亲的交代，把丝绸[9]和纸卖了好价钱，又买了玻璃杯、银器和香料[10]。他还找到了爷爷的弟弟——一位头发全白了的老人。

26 老人听说他是从长安来的康家孩子，激动得说不出话来。

1 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
2 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
3 龟兹 *Qiūcí* Kucha
4 葱岭 *Cōnglǐng* the Pamir Mountains
5 长安 *Cháng'ān* Chang'an, the Tang capital
6 撒马尔罕 *Sāmǎ'ěrhǎn* Samarkand
7 康 *Kāng* Kang (surname)
8 粟特语 *Sùtèyǔ* Sogdian language
9 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
10 香料 *xiāngliào* spices

Only then did Kang Ning understand what Old Shi had meant that night by the campfire by "things that can't be worked out with numbers". 24

What He Brought Back

Later the caravan passed through Kucha and crossed the high Pamirs, and about half a year after leaving Chang'an they finally reached Samarkand. This was the Kang family's old home. Outside the city there were vineyards everywhere, and people spoke the Sogdian he had heard at home since he was small. Following his father's instructions, Kang Ning sold the silk and paper for good prices, and bought glassware, silverware and spices. He also found his grandfather's younger brother, an old man whose hair had turned completely white. 25

When the old man heard that he was a Kang child from Chang'an, he was so moved he couldn't speak. 26

26 他拿出一个旧铃，放在康宁[†]手里：“这是我们父亲年轻时挂在骆驼[‡]身上的铃。你爷爷去了长安[§]，就再也没有回来。这个铃我一直留着，就是在等康[¶]家的孩子来拿。它卖不了几个钱，可是它在这条路上走过很多次。”

27 离开长安一年多以后，康宁跟着商队回到了长安。中午，西市[*]的鼓声响起来的时候，他拉着老灰[#]走到了自己家的店门口。父亲看了看他带回来的货，满意地点了点头，然后又看见了老灰身上那个旧铃。“这头骆驼又老又走不快，”父亲说，“你为什么还把它带回来？还有这个铃……”父亲的话忽然停了。他小时候听自己的父亲说过这个铃。

† 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
‡ 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
§ 长安 *Cháng'ān* Chang'an, the Tang capital
¶ 康 *Kāng* Kang (surname)
* 西市 *Xīshì* the West Market of Chang'an
老灰 *Lǎo Huī* Old Grey (a camel)

He took out an old bell and put it in Kang Ning's hand. "This is the bell our father hung on his camel when he was young. Your grandfather went to Chang'an and never came back. I've kept this bell all these years, waiting for a Kang child to come for it. It won't fetch much money, but it has travelled this road many times." 26

More than a year after he had left, Kang Ning came back to Chang'an with the caravan. At noon, as the drums of the West Market began to sound, he led Old Grey up to the door of his family's shop. His father looked over the goods he had brought back and nodded with satisfaction, and then he noticed the old bell on Old Grey. "This camel is old and slow," his father said. "Why did you bring it back? And this bell..." His father suddenly stopped. As a boy, he had heard his own father talk about this bell. 27

28 康宁[1]笑了。他想起了敦煌[2]的张掌柜、沙漠里的风、老石[3]的水袋，还有撒马尔罕[4]那位白头发的老人。“爸爸，以前我觉得做买卖很简单，就是在便宜的地方买，到贵的地方卖。现在我知道了，这条路上最贵的东西，是人和人之间的信任，再有钱的人也买不起。这头骆驼[5]和这个铃，就是我这一次带回来的最重要的东西。”

29 父亲看了他很久，最后把那个旧铃挂在了店门口。从那以后，每次有风吹过，铃就叮当[6]叮当地响。跟以往不一样的是，康宁的本子上不只写着价格和数字，最后一页还写着一路上帮助过他的人的名字。他知道，正是这些人，将这条长长的路连在了一起，从而让丝绸[7]、纸、佛经[8]、音乐和故事，从东边走到西边，又从西边走回东边。

1 康宁 *Kāng Níng* Kang Ning
2 敦煌 *Dūnhuáng* Dunhuang
3 老石 *Lǎo Shí* Old Shi
4 撒马尔罕 *Sāmǎ'ěrhǎn* Samarkand
5 骆驼 *luòtuo* camel
6 叮当 *dīngdāng* ding-dong
7 丝绸 *sīchóu* silk
8 佛经 *fójīng* Buddhist scriptures

Kang Ning smiled. He thought of Shopkeeper Zhang in Dunhuang, the wind in the desert, Old Shi's water bag, and the white-haired old man in Samarkand. "Dad, I used to think trading was simple: buy where things are cheap and sell where they're dear. Now I know that the most valuable thing on this road is trust between people. Even the richest man couldn't afford to buy it. This camel and this bell are the most important things I've brought back from this journey." 28

His father looked at him for a long time, and at last hung the old bell by the shop door. From then on, whenever the wind blew, the bell went ding-dong, ding-dong. Unlike before, Kang Ning's notebook held more than prices and numbers: on the last page he had written the names of the people who had helped him along the way. He knew it was these very people who had joined this long road together, and so let silk, paper, Buddhist scriptures, music and stories travel from east to west, and back again from west to east. 29